

scheduling ability. The icing on the cake is the low load it places on your system.

Price: \$ 49.95 ■ **System requirements:** 300 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, Windows 98, Me, NT Workstation 4.0, 2000 Pro with SP2, XP, Internet Explorer 4.01 with SP2 ■ **Web site:** www.trendmicro.com ■ **Grade:** A

Quick Heal X-GEN

Started in 1993, Cat Computer Services initially developed copy protection systems. It later diversified into anti-virus software with the development of Quick Heal. This Indian company has become one of the leading Indian developers of anti-virus solutions.

It's heartening to see Indian products that compare with what the world's leaders have to offer. It might have come out at the bottom of the heap in the anti-virus tests, but it's still good enough to make the cut. The program is light in resource utilisation and provides an interface that's pleasing to the eye. Detailed configuration options tie up a nicely made package, apart from a couple of glitches in the interface. With a little more work put into the virus detection, this has the potential of becoming a formidable, yet affordable program.

Price: \$ 30.00 ■ **System requirements:** 486 class CPU, 32 MB RAM, 15 MB hard disk space, Windows 95, 98, Me, NT, 2000, XP ■ **Web site:** www.quickheal.com ■ **Grade:** B+

Who's the strongest of them all?

As far as virus detection is concerned, catching ITW (In The Wild—a term referring to malicious code on the rampage) and Zoo (if the infection has been contained, it's said to have been placed in the Zoo) viruses is of utmost importance, and they have been given the most weightage in the virus detection tests. In this category, there is hardly any difference in the performance of the contenders, each of them catching practically all viruses. Where they significantly differ is in the treatment of viruses that exist in compressed files, documents and spreadsheets. In the end, MicroWorld's eScan comes out tops.

However, raw virus detection should never be taken as the only measure of a virus-buster's performance. eScan is a classic example of this. It uses the Kaspersky Labs engine, which is a really powerful virus eliminator. However, any newbie would be daunted by the awkward interface it has. It's a real pity, because ease of use is all it would've needed to beat the competition hollow.

So, user friendliness is another desirable quality of a program. In this category, AVG, McAfee, and PC-cillin share the honours. Each scored more in certain counts and a little less in others. McAfee also managed to score where it mattered most—in the equally significant test of the configurability of the program. Here, it beat the competition hands down, enabling it to come out tops in the overall scores. 🏆

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